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Rahul's politics is a blend of his great grandfather's socialism and his father's policies of liberalisation. He is concerned about Bharat but not apologetic about India. "If one has to help the poor of this country, economic growth is vital. Where did the money for the NREGA come from? It came from the 8 per cent GDP growth of this country," he says, attacking both the Left and the Right. "On one side, the BJP ignores distribution while the Left ignores generation of resources."

The New Idiom of GOVERNANCE

The party's youngest general secretary is clearly the most important player in the Congress troika—Manmohan, Sonia and Rahul—because he is the face of the future. He is not part of the party's core group that gathers at the prime minister's residence during a crisis, but his input is the most crucial and at times, the most decisive. It was he who set the tone of the last election campaign and decided against alliances. Sometimes, however, Sonia steps in. While Rahul wanted to go it alone in the Maharashtra polls, she refused to break ties with the NCP as unlike Uttar Pradesh, the party had higher stakes in Maharashtra. But Rahul's presence is becoming more visible, beyond his brief as a general secretary. He is there at Sonia's side, when Hillary Clinton comes calling or even when a sulking DMK Chief M. Karunanidhi drops in at 10 Janpath. His performance in Parliament has been perfunctory, except for his defence of the nuclear deal, where he good-naturedly took some ragging by the Opposition benches.

There has been a marked progression, however, in his own politics during the six years since he stepped into his inheritance. Earlier, he was readying himself for leadership, discovering both India and his own legacy. Now, however, it is clear that the Educating Rahul phase of his politics is over. What he is now trying to do is to mould the party according to his vision for the Congress. His night-overs in rural India are now part of the party's official programme. Other young MPs such as Sachin Pilot, Prasada and Jyotiraditya Scindia are doing the same. "He has shown by example not to remain cocooned within the party headquarters," says Pilot.

The Youth Congress is just the incubator for some of Rahul's experiments with leadership. He admits that it would be tougher to bring in democracy in the main organisation, and knows that delivery does not always measure up to intent. But for now, he says, he is content with setting systems in place. "I am just an enabler," says Rahul, explaining, "I can't empower the youth but the Youth Congress can. I am just the catalyst". He is also idealistic enough to ask the Youth Congress to keep out tainted ticket seekers, but realistic

THE GEEK

He is always seen smsing furiously on his BlackBerry Pearl, even while sitting on the dais at party functions. A techie, he has impressed corporate honchos by making detailed presentations to them on his plans for the Youth Congress. He's also fond of early morning bike rides on his Kawasaki on Delhi's streets or sometimes at India Gate.



THE INSIDERS

The convent-educated Milind Deora, Jitin Prasada, Sachin Pilot and Madhu Yaskhi were all backbenchers in the last Parliament session along with Rahul. Like him, each was a professional before he joined politics. However, it is late governor S.K. Singh's son, Kanishka, who is his man Friday.



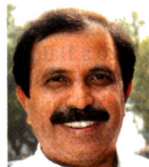
DEORA



PRASADA



PILOT



YASKHI